



Reading Emotions 

ABOUT

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CITIZEN READERS

ORGANIZATION: CITIZEN READERS

Help us annotate the emotions of
literary characters to build AI that
can better understand human
storytelling.

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The goal of this project is to better understand the emotional complexity of literary characters and make this data openly available to the public. Characters are the scaffolding of great storytelling. This Zooniverse project will allow us to crowdsource data to train AI models to better understand the emotions of characters at significantly larger scales than researchers have ever been able to in the past. Our guiding research question is: why are imaginary stories so important to us?

In the nineteenth-century heyday of the novel, there were over 1.5 *million* literary characters invented just in English alone. Today, with the continued growth of literary markets around the world and the explosion of creative writing on the internet through fan communities, that number is orders of magnitude higher.

How on earth can we possibly understand all of this creativity?

This is where you, the reader, come in. We need your help to build better, more transparent AI models to understand human storytelling. To be clear: our goal is not to build AI to generate stories or create smarter chatbots. Our aim is fundamentally academic: we want to develop models to help us *understand* stories and thus learn more about this essential human activity. Most AI development is happening inside of black boxes and behind closed doors. Our models will be open to the public as will all of the annotations made by readers like you. You are a key participant in how we will understand the future of stories.

Tutorial

Welcome to Reading Emotions!

In this project, you will be asked to label the different emotions that characters are feeling.

The emotions of characters are central to how we feel connected to stories. But they can be very complex and subtle. In order to support our goal of understanding stories at large scale, we need your help in making explicit the emotional depth and complexity of literary characters.

Continue



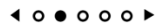
Cicero spent much of the remainder of the year swinging between nervousness and sudden optimism.

How it works

You will be given a sentence taken from a book with a character highlighted.

First you will be asked to confirm that the highlighted word is indeed a character. Characters can be any kind of person or agent -- proper names like "Cicero", pronouns (he, she, they, I), animal names ("Frog"), aliens, robots, etc. Sometimes the character will be a phrase like "the woman from downstairs". That counts too. So do plurals ("**they** were all scared"). These are all examples of characters.

Continue



Emotion Labeling

Once you have determined the highlighted word is a character, you will then have the opportunity to **write-in** your answer. You may write more than one emotion but please separate your answers by commas (capitalization doesn't matter).

If you have trouble thinking of the right emotion, you can use [this visual guide](#) or we suggest using a thesaurus to generate more suggestions on associated emotions.

What emotions are the highlighted character feeling? Write in your answer. If you choose to write multiple answers, please separate them by commas. If you are unable to tell from the sentence leave the box blank and hit submit.

nervous, optimistic

Back

Done



Continue



What if I can't tell?

This is an important possibility. In some cases, it may be very subtle or implicit. For example: "No, I don't want to play anymore." What do we think the speaker is feeling? It's hard to say. You might either choose to leave it blank or feel that the character is feeling "frustrated." It's up to you to decide!

In other examples, however, it is very clear you can't tell the character's emotion. For example: "**Annabelle** slept in the apartment with me and I was full of fear." Here we can infer what the speaker ("I") is feeling but not what Annabelle is feeling. In this case, we leave the text box **blank**.

Continue



If you have any questions / concerns

Just hit the talk button and add a comment about what you find confusing or difficult for a given character or question or check out our field guide for more guidance.

**** Warning **** There may be occasional violent or sexual content.

Let's go!





FINISHED!

She liked Mrs. Boyd; she felt a slightly contemptuous but real affection for her.



TASK

TUTORIAL

Is the highlight a character?

Yes

No (Highlight is not a character or there is some error with the passage.)

NEED SOME HELP WITH THIS TASK?

Done & Talk

Done



FIELD GUIDE



FINISHED!

She liked Mrs. Boyd; she felt a slightly contemptuous but real affection for her.



TASK

TUTORIAL

What emotions is the highlighted character feeling? Write in your answer. If you choose to write multiple answers, please separate them by commas. If you are unable to tell from the sentence, leave the box blank and hit submit.

NEED SOME HELP WITH THIS TASK?

Back

Done & Talk

Done

